

OET READING

COMPREHENSIVE RULEBOOK

Exam Structure · Timing · Navigation · Marking Rules · AI Training Edition

PURPOSE OF THIS DOCUMENT

This rulebook defines the structure, sequence, timing, permitted actions, and marking rules of the OET Reading sub-test. It is intended for AI platform training only — not for candidates. Rule codes: **R04.3** = Section 4, Rule 3. **CRITICAL** rules (red) = facts that directly affect scoring or validity.

THE TUTOR BOOK · OET Preparation by Dr. Ahmed Hesham · @DrAhmedHesham

01 EXAM OVERVIEW & SEQUENCE	
R01.1	Reading is the second sub-test in the OET exam. The sequence is: Listening → Reading → Writing → Speaking.
R01.2	Total questions: 42. Three parts: Part A (20 questions / 20 marks), Part B (6 questions / 6 marks), Part C (16 questions / 16 marks).
R01.3	Part A is a standalone section with its own 15-minute time block. Part B and Part C are delivered together in a shared 45-minute block.
R01.4	Total Reading exam duration: 60 minutes (15 min Part A + 45 min Parts B and C).
R01.5	Part C is divided into C1 (8 questions) and C2 (8 questions).
R01.6	Reading applies the same format and content for ALL OET professions.
02 SCORING & PASS REQUIREMENTS	
R02.1	30 correct answers out of 42 = Grade B = 350 points = minimum passing score for doctors (GMC, ECFMG) and nurses (NMC).
R02.2	Scoring scale: Grade A = 450+, Grade B = 350–449, Grade C+ = 300–349, Grade C = 250–299, Grade D = below 250.
R02.3	Each correct answer = 1 mark. No negative marking for wrong answers.
R02.4	CRITICAL — No combining (clipping) of scores across exam sittings for Medicine pathways (GMC, ECFMG, Canada). All four sub-tests must be passed in one sitting.
R02.5	Some nursing pathways (NMC) permit combining sub-test scores across sittings. This does not apply to Medicine.
03 PART A — STRUCTURE & QUESTION TYPES	
R03.1	Part A contains 4 texts: Text A, Text B, Text C, Text D. All 4 texts relate to a single clinical or healthcare topic.
R03.2	Part A has three question types across 20 questions: · Q1–7: Matching — candidate writes the letter (A/B/C/D) of the text containing the stated information. · Q8–14: Short answer — candidate writes a word, short phrase, or number taken directly from the text. · Q15–20: Sentence completion — candidate writes the single missing word or number to complete the sentence.
R03.3	Text C almost always contains a table, graph, or chart. Recent exams have also placed tables in Texts A, B, or D.
R03.4	Part A is a note-completion and short-answer section. Answers must be sourced directly from the text — they are not opinion-based.
R03.5	Part A timing: 15 minutes. In the paper-based exam, the text booklet and answer sheet are separate. In the computer-based exam, text appears on the left panel and questions on the right panel.
R03.6	CRITICAL — After 15 minutes: in the paper-based exam the invigilator collects Part A papers. In the computer-based exam the text panel locks automatically. No further access to Part A is possible.
04 PART A — MARKING & ACCURACY RULES	
R04.1	CRITICAL — Spelling error in a Part A answer: any incorrect letter in a word = the entire word is marked wrong. The answer is expected to be copied directly from the text.
R04.2	CRITICAL — Singular/plural error: writing the wrong number form (singular instead of plural, or vice versa) = answer marked wrong.

R04.3	CRITICAL — Incorrect form of the answer: writing a range when the question asks for a maximum, or writing a dose per kg when the question asks for a total dose, = wrong answer.
R04.4	Numbers must be written exactly as they appear in the text — correct units, decimal notation, and formatting are required.
R04.5	CRITICAL — Reading Part A has stricter spelling rules than Listening Part A. In Reading, any spelling error results in the answer being marked wrong with no exceptions.
R04.6	CRITICAL — Answers for Q8–14 and Q15–20 must come word-for-word from the text. Paraphrasing or synonyms are not accepted.

05 PART A — TIMING RULES

R05.1	CRITICAL — Part A has a strict 15-minute time limit. When time expires, writing stops (paper-based) or the screen locks (computer-based).
R05.2	In the computer-based exam: when the 15-minute timer reaches zero, the Part A text panel locks and the candidate proceeds automatically to the optional break screen before Part B and C.
R05.3	CRITICAL — In the paper-based exam: the invigilator announces "Pencils down" at 15 minutes and collects the Part A answer sheets and text booklets. No further writing is permitted.
R05.4	Part A answer sheet is separate from the Part B and C question booklet in the paper-based exam. Collecting Part A papers does not affect access to Parts B and C.

06 PART B — STRUCTURE & TIMING

R06.1	Part B consists of 6 questions. Each question has its own short, independent text.
R06.2	Part B texts are short passages. Each text and its corresponding question appear on the same page.
R06.3	Each Part B question has 3 answer choices (A, B, C). Exactly one is correct.
R06.4	Part B carries 6 marks (1 mark per question).
R06.5	Part B and Part C share the same 45-minute time block and are contained in the same booklet.

07 PART C — STRUCTURE & TIMING

R07.1	Part C consists of 2 long texts: C1 and C2. Each carries 8 questions. Total: 16 questions / 16 marks.
R07.2	Each Part C text is approximately 7–8 paragraphs long.
R07.3	CRITICAL — Each Part C question has 4 answer choices (A, B, C, D). Exactly one is correct.
R07.4	CRITICAL — Part B has 3 choices; Part C has 4 choices. This distinction is important for the AI to recognise correctly.
R07.5	C1 and C2 are on completely different topics with no connection to each other.
R07.6	Part C questions follow paragraph order within each text. Question 1 of C1 corresponds to the first paragraph; question 8 to the last. Questions do not reverse direction.
R07.7	If a paragraph contains an underlined word or sentence, approximately 2 questions from that paragraph are expected.
R07.8	Approximately 4–5 questions per Part C text are based on the writer's point of view or implied meaning, rather than explicitly stated facts. Two answer choices may both appear plausible; the task is to identify the more correct one.

R07.9	The remaining 11–12 questions per Part C text have answers directly and explicitly stated in the text.
R07.10	Part C and Part B share the same 45-minute block. Time allocation within this block is not enforced by the exam — it is entirely the candidate's responsibility.

08 PARTS B & C — MARKING & INTERACTION RULES

R08.1	Each question in Parts B and C = 1 mark. There is no negative marking.
R08.2	Only one answer choice can be selected per question. Selecting more than one is not permitted.
R08.3	CRITICAL — An unanswered question = 0 marks. The system does not auto-fill blank answers.
R08.4	In the computer-based exam: left-clicking an answer choice selects it (highlighted in selection colour). Right-clicking applies a strikethrough (elimination) without selecting.
R08.5	CRITICAL — Strikethrough / elimination in the computer-based exam does NOT count as a selected answer. The candidate must still left-click a final answer.
R08.6	In the paper-based exam: candidates fill in the answer circle (A, B, C, or D) on the answer sheet. Partial fills or ambiguous marks may be rejected.

09 NAVIGATION RULES — COMPUTER-BASED EXAM

R09.1	CRITICAL — No break between the Listening and Reading sub-tests in the computer-based exam. Reading begins automatically after Listening ends.
R09.2	Between Part A and Parts B+C in the computer-based exam: a 10-minute optional break is offered. The candidate may press "Resume Test" to skip it and proceed immediately.
R09.3	CRITICAL — After the 15-minute Part A period: the Part A text panel locks permanently. No access to Part A content or answers is possible after this point.
R09.4	Within the 45-minute Parts B+C block: the candidate moves through questions sequentially. Navigation rules vary by delivery mode (see below).
R09.5	In the computer-based exam, the candidate moves forward through questions by pressing Next. Confirmation is required at certain section boundaries.
R09.6	CRITICAL — At the end of the 45-minute Parts B+C block in the computer-based exam: the screen locks and the Reading sub-test ends. No further answers can be submitted.

10 DISPLAY & INTERACTION — COMPUTER-BASED EXAM

R10.1	Part A display: the text appears on the LEFT panel of the screen. The questions and answer boxes appear on the RIGHT panel — a split-screen layout.
R10.2	Parts B and C display: each short Part B text appears on the same screen as its question. Each Part C long text appears alongside the corresponding questions on the same screen.
R10.3	The timer is always visible on screen throughout the computer-based exam.
R10.4	Part A — Highlighting: available and functional. Candidates may highlight text in the passage during Part A.
R10.5	CRITICAL — Part A — Copy-paste: not always available. It is unreliable and varies by exam centre. It cannot be depended upon.
R10.6	Parts B and C — Highlighting the text passage: permitted.
R10.7	Parts B and C — Highlighting the question stem: permitted.

R10.8	CRITICAL — Parts B and C — Highlighting the answer choices (A/B/C/D): NOT permitted.
R10.9	Parts B and C — Eliminating an answer choice: right-click applies a strikethrough to a choice without selecting it.
R10.10	CRITICAL — Zoom: + and – buttons within the exam application control zoom. The browser keyboard shortcut Ctrl+ is blocked in the exam environment.
R10.11	In the computer-based exam, candidates cannot write paragraph numbers in the margins or make physical annotations.

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TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS — COMPUTER-BASED EXAM

R11.1	CRITICAL — Minimum screen resolution: 1920 × 1080. Below this, the split-screen layout fails — text and questions overlap or are cut off.
R11.2	CRITICAL — Display scale (Windows): 100% or maximum 125%. Scale above 125% causes interface panels to overlap and clip.
R11.3	CRITICAL — At-home candidates: must configure screen resolution and display scale before exam day. Failure has caused exam cancellations.
R11.4	The exam runs inside a dedicated application (ProProctor), not a regular browser.
R11.5	CRITICAL — Internet connection: must be stable throughout the exam. An unstable connection can interrupt the exam session.
R11.6	All VPNs and virtual machines must be disabled before launching the exam application.
R11.7	At test centres: split screen and display settings are pre-configured. No candidate action is required. This applies to at-home candidates only.

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NAVIGATION RULES — PAPER-BASED EXAM

R12.1	In the paper-based exam, there is a natural 10-minute transition between Listening and Reading while papers are collected and new papers are distributed.
R12.2	Part A: two separate documents are distributed — the text booklet (Texts A, B, C, D) and the answer sheet.
R12.3	CRITICAL — After 15 minutes: the invigilator collects both the Part A text booklet and answer sheet. Access to Part A is permanently over.
R12.4	Parts B and C are delivered in a single combined booklet. The text and the question appear together in the same document.
R12.5	In the paper-based exam, the candidate can view and write in any question across Parts B and C at any time within the 45-minute block. There are no section locks.
R12.6	In the paper-based exam, candidates may write paragraph numbers in the margins and annotate the question paper freely with a pencil.
R12.7	Highlighting and underlining in the paper-based exam: permitted in all parts using a pencil.
R12.8	Timer in the paper-based exam: displayed on a wall projector or clock visible to all candidates. The invigilator announces time warnings.
R12.9	Part C paper-based format: the long text and the answer choices may be on different pages within the booklet, requiring the candidate to flip between them. This is a key structural difference from the computer-based exam where both are on the same screen.